

Dvar Torah Outline — Hallel (Tehillim 117 & 118): Chessed, Emes, “Paying Back” Hashem Through Hoda’ah, and Distinct Recipients of Divine Kindness

Abstract

This dvar Torah (following the Maharal's flow through Hallel) addresses a theological tension: if Hashem governs with chessed—giving beyond strict deserving—does that compromise emes (truth/consistency)? The answer is that Hashem's chessed itself is integrated into emes through a larger, exact accounting across time and roles in Creation. The piece then reframes “repayment” to Hashem: we cannot truly pay Him back with offerings or mitzvot as transactions, only through הודאה—acknowledgment that returns the gift to its source by giving ourselves over to Him. Finally, it explains why Hallel highlights different circles—Israel, Beit Aharon, and Yir'ei Hashem—each receiving a distinct manifestation of chessed.

I. The starting point in Hallel: universal praise, then a philosophical problem

A. The paragraph being studied

- **Tehillim 117:1–2**

- "הָלְלוּ אֶת־ה' כָּל־גּוֹיִם שִׁבְחוּהוּ כָל־הָאֲמִיּוֹת כִּי גָבַר עָלֵינוּ חֲסִדּוֹ וְאֶמֶת־ה' לְעוֹלָם הִלְלוּהָ"
- (Praise Hashem, all nations... for His kindness has overwhelmed us; and the truth of Hashem is forever, hallelujah.)

B. The tension: chessed can look “untrue”

- A person might think:
 - Hashem runs the world **only** with chessed,
 - and therefore not with emes.
- Conceptual distinction introduced:
 - **Din** is “true” in the sense of consistent, earned, and proportional.
 - **Chessed** seems to “violate” strict emes: giving even when not deserved.

- Key framing line:
 - Chessed appears to be *from the giver* (“I give because I give”),
 - whereas din appears to be *from the recipient* (“you have a right/fitness”).

C. The pasuk’s response

- “אֱמֶת־ה’ לְעוֹלָם”
 - Even when Hashem acts with chessed, it is still בתוך אמת—part of a true framework, not randomness.

II. Chessed “within emes”: Chazal’s model of long-range accounting

A. General principle attributed to Chazal

- When Hashem introduces actions that look like chessed beyond emes,
 - He “equalizes” reality back to emes,
 - so there is no permanent deviation from truth.

B. The Gemara in Pesachim: Avraham in the fiery furnace

- Story cited:
 - Nimrod throws Avraham into the furnace.
 - Gavriel asks to save him.
 - Hashem responds:
 - “אֲנִי יְחִיד בְּעוֹלָמִי וְאַבְרָהָם יְחִיד בְּעוֹלָמוֹ, נִצָּה לְיְחִיד לְהַצִּיל אֶת הַיְחִיד.”
 - (I am unique in My world and Avraham is unique in his world; it is fitting that the Unique saves the unique.)

C. “Hashem does not withhold reward from any creature” — even for a malach

- Claim:
 - “אֵין הַקְדוּשׁ בְּרוּךְ הוּא מְקַפֵּחַ שְׂכָר שׁוֹם בְּרִיָּה”
- Question raised:
 - Malachim don’t choose via free will like humans—so what does “reward” mean here?
- Proposed explanation:
 - Even without free will, each created being has a **role/potential** embedded in its existence.

- To block a being from expressing its created role would be a diminishment of its place in Creation.
- Therefore Hashem “pays out” even that role-expression in a later form.

D. The “make-up” salvation: Chananya, Mishael, Azarya

- Since Gavriel did not save Avraham, Hashem grants him later “payment”:
 - Gavriel saves **Chananya, Mishael, and Azarya** from Nevuchadnetzar’s furnace.
- The theological conclusion drawn:
 - The overall ledger returns to “וְאֵת־הַכֹּל לְעוֹלָם”—everything lands in emes when viewed across time.

E. “Deviation now, emes later”: broader historical examples

- Nadav and Avihu:
 - Idea referenced: they may have been liable earlier (around Matan Torah), but payment was delayed so as not to disrupt that moment.
- A “payment plan” model (linked to Derech Hashem):
 - Some debts are collected in smaller installments over time (e.g., aftermath of the Eigel).
- The 400 vs. 210 years theme:
 - The Egyptian bondage was foretold as 400 years, yet the actual stay was 210.
 - The remaining “truth-accounting” unfolds through continued exiles—history completes the אמת.

III. Transition to Tehillim 118: “Hodu” and what it means to repay Hashem

A. The pasuk people say with fervor—often without its depth

- **Tehillim 118:1**
 - “הוֹדוּ לַה' כִּי־טוֹב כִּי לְעוֹלָם חַסְדּוֹ”
 - (Give thanks to Hashem for He is good; His kindness is forever.)

B. Midrash/Gemara idea: Israel’s only “payment” is gratitude

- Principle:
 - Israel cannot truly “pay” Hashem back except with הודאה.
- Supporting verses:
 - **Tehillim 118:21**
 - “אֹדֶךְ כִּי עָבִיתָנִי וְתַהֲיֶי־לִי לִישׁוּעָה”

- (I thank You for You answered me and became my salvation.)

- **Tehillim 118:28**

- "אֱלֹהֵי אֲתָנָה וְאֶדְוָךְ"
- (You are my God and I will thank You.)

IV. Maharal's definition: Hoda'ah is "hashlamah"—giving yourself over

A. Hoda'ah is not just polite thanks

- is framed as "הוֹדָאָה"
 - admitting/acknowledging,
 - and thereby completing oneself toward the giver.

B. The psychological-spiritual mechanism

- Core definition:
 - "כָּל מִי שֶׁמוֹדָה לְאַחֵר מְשָׁלִים עֲצָמוֹ אֵלָיו"
 - Whoever acknowledges another becomes "under their authority" in that domain.
- Applied to Hashem:
 - Hoda'ah makes a person "belong" to Hashem—placing self and life under His reshut.

C. Why this is the only true repayment

- You can't repay Hashem through "giving Him something," because:
 - everything you have (life, abilities, opportunities) came from Him already.
- The only coherent "currency":
 - to give **yourself** back—your nefesh, your identity, your agency—through acknowledgment and submission to His sourcehood.
- Side note invoked:
 - Hoda'ah as connected to the sefirah of הוֹד:
 - acknowledgment "returns" the gift to its origin (even if you still physically possess it).

D. Practical interpersonal echo

- Even בין אדם לחברו:
 - gratitude creates a bond and a sense of indebtedness/relationship.

- But the Torah-level absolute version is only possible vis-à-vis Hashem:
 - because no human gave you everything, while Hashem did.
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V. “Ki tov” and “ki l’olam chasdo”: the structure of universal chessed

A. What “tov” means here

- Hashem’s nature is to bestow good = “טוב”
 - “טוב הוא מחק הטוב להיטיב” (goodness as an essential drive to do good).

B. Universal call

- is first framed as addressed broadly “הודו לה’...”
 - all creations should acknowledge Hashem's chessed.
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VI. Why the psalm then narrows: Israel, Beit Aharon, and Yir’ei Hashem

A. The next pesukim

- Tehillim 118:2–4
 - “יאמר־נָא יִשְׂרָאֵל כִּי לְעוֹלָם חֲסִדוֹ יֹאמְרוּ־נָא בֵּית־אַהֲרֹן כִּי לְעוֹלָם חֲסִדוֹ יֹאמְרוּ־נָא יִרְאֵי ה’ כִּי לְעוֹלָם חֲסִדוֹ”
 - (Let Israel say... Let the house of Aharon say... Let those who fear Hashem say... His kindness is forever.)

B. First layer: different recipients, different “types” of chessed

- Chessed is “divided” (מחולקים):
 - Hashem relates with distinct chassadim to different circles.

C. Israel: chessed of a parent-child bond

- Israel receives unique chessed because:
 - “לְפִי שְׁהֵם בְּנֵי בְּעֵצִים”
 - They are essentially His children—relationship itself generates chessed.

D. Beit Aharon: chessed tied to love and role

- Beit Aharon receives unique chessed because:
 - they are “אוהבי השם,”
 - and as kohanim they embody chessed (midah k'neged midah: a chessed-role invites chessed).

E. Yir'ei Hashem: an unresolved question (to be developed)

- The speaker flags:
 - What exactly is the “unique chessed” granted specifically to 'יראי ה'?
 - This requires further explanation, and will be revisited.

F. Why all were included together first

- Even though their chassadim differ in kind/degree:
 - all are equal in one respect:
 - the proper response is הודאה—acknowledgment and self-completion toward Hashem.

VII. Roadmap / continuation note

- The speaker plans to return to an earlier “three-group” discussion (connected to a prior paragraph) and develop:
 - why these three categories appear,
 - and what distinguishes “the unique chessed” for each—especially 'יראי ה'.
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VIII. In Summary

- Chessed does not contradict emes; it is part of a larger אמת-accounting that unfolds across time and roles.
- The Pesachim narrative (Avraham/Gavriel) illustrates how Hashem “balances” apparent deviations back into truth.
- giving oneself back—הודו לה' כי טוב... teaches that the only true repayment to Hashem is “הודו לה' כי טוב” through acknowledgment.
- Tehillim 118 distinguishes Israel, Beit Aharon, and Yir'ei Hashem as recipients of different manifestations of chessed, while uniting them under one universal response: הודאה.